



Design Document (Revised)

by

Defenestration

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## Overview

### Description

Primordial Mass is a survival-horror roguelite with a focus on exploring an otherworldly and shifting environment.

### Platform

The game will target PCs.

### Target Audience

The game is intended for enjoyers of roguelikes/roguelites that want a slower paced twist on the genre. It should also appeal to people who like the thrill of being chased in survival-horror games and the cosmic-horror aesthetic.

### Player Fantasy

The main fantasy of the game should serve is one of exploration, providing a sense of wonder, mixed with a sense of unease from the horror elements. An example of this mix would be Subnautica.

# Gameplay

## General

The gameplay will be focused on individual, repetitive runs that take anywhere from 10 to 60 minutes. A run starts in a “safe room” with the exit to finish a run also being located here. The player will then continually explore randomly generated rooms containing different kinds of collectibles and obstacles. The main goal will revolve around collecting materials to upgrade the player’s ability to reach further into the realm. Runs will be extended by the player finding a certain type of object and placing it at designated spots. Along the way, the player character will find artifacts belonging to their loved one, eventually leading the player to encounter them. The game will be displayed in a top-down perspective.

## Controls

The game will have a very basic control scheme. The player can move in all directions and have a button to interact with things, like activating objects or picking up items. They will also be able to sprint by holding another button. The game will support keyboard and controllers.

## HUD

During gameplay, the game will feature a progress bar at the bottom that tracks the “Stability” value that is displayed at all times. Additionally, a stamina is displayed whenever the player’s current stamina is not at the maximum value. It will also visually change when it is fully depleted, indicating that the player can’t sprint and needs to wait until it is recharged.

# Systems

## Procedural Generation

Players will explore a completely generated top-down map, split apart into rooms. These rooms will contain a random shape mapped onto a 16x16 grid of tiles, with linear paths branching to adjacent rooms. They will then be filled with enemies and other objects under consideration of neighbouring rooms.

## Illusions

Sections on the map, meaning a few adjacent rooms, will have a certain “modifier” attached to them. This will be in the form of various things that fit the “illusion” theme. For example, enemies could all be camouflaged within the environment.

## Stamina

The player's sprint depletes a stamina value. If this value reaches its minimum, the player must wait for a cooldown to finish until they can sprint again.

## Mental Stability

During exploration, the player's actions will decrease a “Stability” value displayed to them with a big progress bar at the bottom of the screen. Once this bar is empty, the cosmic entity inhabiting this dimension will become enraged.

This will cause a wave of primordial mass to start closing in on the starting area from further beyond where the player has explored. This will force the player to retreat and exit through the starting portal and finish their run.

When the enrage event is triggered, already explored parts of the map will be shuffled around and regenerated randomly to make the run toward the exit more challenging.

In the enraged state, enemies will also become more aggressive, with an even sharper increase to those that are further away from the start.

The player can find pearls and place them on pillars found in some rooms, which give them materials and raise the stability value by a certain amount.

## Meta progression

During a run, players will collect materials. They can use these in between runs to upgrade various stats such as maximum stability or stamina.

With these upgrades, they will gradually be able to explore further and faster.

When a player dies during a run, either by being caught by the primordial mass or being hit while stability is empty, they will lose all of the materials and items collected within the run.

## Enemies

The player will encounter enemies distributed through the realm. Engaging with them directly will be dangerous, since the player can not directly fight them. Instead they can be defeated using various objects and some items also found during a run. Whether to engage or avoid should feel like a strategic decision, with the better choice being dependent on the player's general situation.

# Plot

## Synopsis

You play as a regular person trying to rescue a loved one who has been trapped in another dimension. This dimension is inhabited by a lovecraftian deity that starts to sense your presence. It rejects you, not out of malice, but simply as a cosmic reaction to an unknown entity entering its environment. There is no clear distinction between the fabric of this reality or the deity inhabiting it.

The other world does not fit within a regular human's frame of mind. Upon your perception, it starts to take shape as endless corridors and rooms made of strange disfigurations of every-day objects and buildings, seemingly normal but horribly wrong upon closer inspection. Strange creatures start to form and stalk you, hunting you like antibodies. You'll have to avoid them to continue your journey, using the strange environment to your advantage.

Continually delve deeper, only retreating to your home to use the materials you find to enhance your abilities. Be careful not to stay too long, for it will drive you insane.

## Main Character - Leyla Reynwood

Leyla Reynwood is a 24-year-old woman that works as an artist and part time as a barista. She lives together with her girlfriend in a small apartment. She has the life goals of marrying her girlfriend and getting a job in a big production company where she can use her artistic passion to its fullest. Considering her determined nature, she is optimistic that she will reach those goals eventually. Despite that, she is not used to anything related to horror and is easily scared by the smallest thing.



Environn

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## A collage of various anime-style characters and creatures. It includes a red robot-like character with a speech bubble saying "COSS CAN", a white skull-like character, a dark creature with large eyes, a colorful blob-like creature, a character with large black eyes, a skeletal figure holding a spear, a character with long dark hair, and a character with glowing yellow eyes. The word "characters" is written in large white letters across the middle.

## Technical Art Style



## Vibe



## Environments

Rooms should feel abandoned and uncanny, with a clash of different architectural styles and time periods. This is to accentuate the fact that the depicted dimension is only shaped by the main character's perception of it, like thoughts blended together and reassembled into an approximation of reality.

Enemies are explained in the story as some of the primordial matter of the strange dimension encapsulating into bespoke creatures, also shaped from the memories and perception of the main character: This leads to them looking like grotesque deformations of animals, with parts of different animals merged together and an all around undefined and unstable, morphing shape. They should, however, not be too gory, but have some sort of common visual pattern like a strange, colorful sludge where there are open wounds or holes. The game is viewed from a top down perspective.

The environment will contain some low poly 3D elements, the walls will be generated to protrude upwards toward the camera. They will be textured with low resolutions of 16x16 or 32x32.

# Sound

## Music / Ambience

The game will feature only minimal music elements to not take away from the horror feeling, barring music during menus. To not have it become too monotonous during repetitive runs, a dynamic ambience system will be used that plays some sounds at random based on in-game factors. To accentuate the otherworldly-ness, the ambience should include synthesizers.

## Sound effects

Sound effects can lean into the distortion of real world objects' themes by consisting of natural sounds that are changed to be uncanny. Especially for enemies, they should be unique enough to differentiate objects. Having eerie sound effects coming from dark will further accentuate a player's sense of unease.

Since the upgrade menu plays a big part, menu sounds should be responsive and satisfying.